



P17 · 32 PAGES, RETURNING TO WORK

A Back-to-Work Pumping Planner

Thirty-two pages for the version of you returning to work who still wants to be feeding the baby. A pumping schedule template, a freezer-stash plan, a milk inventory log, conversation scripts for the supervisor who keeps forgetting, a "what to do when the pump room is bad" page, and a sample travel-day plan. Practical, no shame.

Soothemade Notes

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you start

The return-to-work moment for a feeding parent is one of the least-supported transitions in modern life. You are simultaneously coordinating: a body still doing a thing it did not finish, a baby being fed by other people, a workplace that may or may not have done this before, and your own sense of who you are now.

This planner is for the logistics. It assumes nothing about your supply, your employer, or your feelings about leaving. It assumes you are doing your best with the body, the boss, and the building you have.

It does not tell you to keep feeding for any specific length of time. It does not tell you to stop. It is here for whichever direction you decide.

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This is a planning tool, not medical advice. If anything feels wrong with your body or with the baby's feeding, talk to a real provider. The trusted numbers are listed at the back of this planner.

Two weeks before you go back

A checklist. Print it once. Do them in any order.

- ☐ Tour the pump room (or identify the room you'll use)
- ☐ Confirm hours / who has the key / who is supposed to know
- ☐ Have the supervisor conversation (script in this planner)
- ☐ Order one set of replacement pump parts (you will lose one)
- ☐ Pack a "left-at-work" backup kit: spare flanges, spare bottles, spare bra, spare top, snack bar, wipes
- ☐ Pack a "left-in-car" backup kit: spare cooler, ice packs
- ☐ Decide on milk-storage labeling system (we offer one below)
- ☐ Set a freezer-stash goal (the math is in this planner)
- ☐ Stock cleaning supplies for parts (basin, brush, soap)
- ☐ Talk to the partner / other caregiver about morning logistics
- ☐ Talk to daycare / caregiver about milk handling (page below)
- ☐ Practice the morning routine ONCE before you do it for real
- ☐ Set up the pumping schedule (template in this planner)

That's it. Do one a day for two weeks. The list is the work. The list also reduces the day-one chaos by about 70 percent.

The freezer stash plan

A page about how much milk to bank before day one, because the internet will tell you many things and most of them are wrong.

The realistic math

A baby roughly drinks 1 to 1.5 oz per hour they are away from you. So:

HOURS AWAY	DAILY MILK NEED	2-DAY BUFFER
8 hrs	8-12 oz	16-24 oz
9 hrs	9-14 oz	18-28 oz
10 hrs	10-15 oz	20-30 oz

A two-day buffer is plenty for most people. You do not need a freezer that looks like the internet's freezer. The internet's freezer is for content, not for you.

When to start stashing

Three to four weeks before return, not earlier (frozen milk lasts about six months, but the most-recently-frozen milk has fat composition closer to current baby's needs).

How to stash without dropping supply

If you are exclusively breastfeeding and starting to pump for the freezer, pump ONE side while the baby feeds the OTHER side, in the morning, when supply is highest. The morning side has roughly 30% more output than midday. You'll bank 1-3 oz per session this way without disrupting the baby's feeds.

The 30-day freezer log

There is a page in the planner for marking down what's in the freezer and when. The format:

DATE FROZEN	OZ	USED ON	NOTE
___/___/___	___ OZ	___	___
___/___/___	___ OZ	___	___
___/___/___	___ OZ	___	___
___/___/___	___ OZ	___	___
(repeat for 30 rows)			

Rotate FIFO (first in, first out). Use older milk first.

The pumping schedule template

A weekly grid. Fill in your specific hours.

WEEK OF _____ / BABY'S AGE: _____ months

MON TUE WED THU FRI

Arrive: _____
Pump 1: _____
Lunch: _____
Pump 2: _____
Pump 3: _____
Depart: _____

OZ OUT, DAILY TOTAL:

Pump 1: _____
Pump 2: _____
Pump 3: _____

TOTAL: _____

THIS WEEK I NOTICED:

NEXT WEEK I WANT TO TRY:

The grid is intentionally repetitive. You fill it in once each Monday morning. It becomes automatic.

Realistic output expectations

The number on the bottle is not a referendum on you. Things to know:

- **Most steady-state pumpers** produce 3-4 oz total per session (between both breasts), about 3 to 5 months postpartum.
- **The first morning pump** is usually the highest, sometimes 5-6 oz.
- **The last pump of the day** is usually the lowest, sometimes 1-2 oz.
- **Pumping output is NOT breastfeeding output.** Babies are more efficient than pumps. A baby gets more milk than a pump does, from the same breast, in the same time.
- **Flange size matters.** If you are not sure your flanges fit, watch the nipple in the tunnel for 30 seconds. If it is rubbing the sides or pulling areola in, you likely need a different size.
- **Hands-on pumping** (gentle compression while pumping) can add 30% to output.

When to worry

If output is dropping by 20% or more over a week and you have not changed schedule, equipment, or sleep, that is worth a lactation consultant conversation. The trusted numbers are at the back.

When not to worry

A single low pump session. An afternoon pump that is small. A morning where you got a phone call mid-pump. These are not data. Three days of consistent low output is data.

The supervisor conversation

Six scripts, one per common scenario. Print these, read them once, then put them away. The fact that you've rehearsed makes the actual conversation feel less like a confrontation.

Script 1, the first conversation, before return

Hi _____,

Before I'm back on _____, I want to flag that I'll be pumping during the workday, like many parents do. I want to set us up for success together.

What I'm planning:

- ☐ Three short pump sessions a day, roughly 20 minutes each, around _____, _____, and _____
- ☐ I'll use _____ as the pump space
(or: I'd like to identify a space that works)

I'll keep work moving. I won't be in meetings during pump times, but I'm reachable on chat.

Can we put this on the calendar so we're aligned?

Thanks,

Script 2, the schedule-conflict conversation

Hi _____,

I noticed _____ is scheduled during one of my pump times. I'd like to move the meeting to _____ if possible, or join via phone from the pump room (I can be on audio but not video).

Either works for me. Let me know which is easier.

Thanks,

Script 3, the “the room is bad” conversation

Hi _____,

The current pump space is not working well. The specific issue is _____

(no lock / shared with storage / too small for the pump and a chair / no outlet).

Could we look at a different space? Some options:

- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____
- ☐ _____

This is a temporary arrangement for me. I'd appreciate help finding something workable.

Thanks,

Script 4, the supply-dropped check-in

If you find your supply dropping because of work logistics, and you want it addressed before it gets worse:

Hi _____,

I want to flag that the current schedule isn't giving me enough time between sessions, which is affecting my supply for the baby. I want to adjust before it becomes a real problem.

What would help:

- ☐ A third pump session in the day (15 min)
- ☐ Slightly longer breaks between meetings
- ☐ _____

I'll continue to deliver, and I want to keep this part working. Let me know what's possible.

Thanks,

Script 5, the “someone said something” response

For when a coworker, manager, or HR person makes a comment that is wrong, unkind, or both.

"I appreciate you bringing this up. Pumping at work is legally protected, and it's how I'm able to be back. I'm going to keep doing it on the schedule we agreed on. If there's a specific concern about how it's affecting my work, I'd want to know that directly. Otherwise, let's move on."

You can soften the tone. The point is to be specific, short, and to redirect.

Script 6, the “I’m done” announcement

When you decide to stop pumping at work (which is yours to decide):

Hi _____,

Heads up that I'm phasing out the pumping breaks in the next ____ weeks. My calendar will open up during those times. Thanks for your support over the last ____ months.

Nothing more is owed.

When the pump room is bad

It will be bad in at least one of the following ways. Here is what to do.

“The pump room is a closet without a lock”

- **Step 1:** A doorstop. Pop it under the door from the inside.
- **Step 2:** A sign on the outside. (“In use. Please knock.”)
- **Step 3:** Escalate (Script 3 above).

“The pump room is the bathroom”

This is legally not allowed in the US under federal law (PUMP Act, 2022). But it happens.

- **Step 1:** Document it. (Date, time, what was offered.)
- **Step 2:** Ask HR for an alternative in writing.
- **Step 3:** Contact your state Department of Labor or the federal Wage and Hour Division if HR does not respond within 5 business days. The PUMP Act has teeth.

“The pump room is in use when I need it”

- **Step 1:** A shared calendar for the room. Suggest it once. (Script 3 again.)
- **Step 2:** An alternative space identified for backup.
- **Step 3:** A heating pad if you have to wait (it helps with comfort).

“Someone walked in on me”

- **Step 1:** Lock or doorstop, immediately, before next time.
- **Step 2:** Sign on outside.

- **Step 3:** A short word with that person, if possible. ("I'm in there pumping. Please knock first.")

"The pump room has no chair"

- **Step 1:** Request one. Most companies will provide.
- **Step 2:** A folding chair from a conference room is a fine workaround.
- **Step 3:** A chair you bring yourself, stored in the room, with a small label.

A travel-day plan

For business travel during pumping months.

Pre-flight, the day before

- Buy ice packs.
- Charge all pump batteries.
- Pack a manual pump as backup. Manual pumps are slow but they work without an outlet.
- Pack a small cooler.
- Pre-label storage bottles with the date.

At the airport

- TSA allows breast milk through security in any quantity. You do NOT have to pour it out. You may have to declare it. Print the TSA rules if your airport is one that pretends not to know.
- A nursing room may be available. Some airports have them. Some don't.
- A bathroom is not an acceptable pump space, but it is often the available one. Pump in the bathroom only if there is no other option.

On the plane

- Pump in your seat with a hands-free bra and a nursing cover if you want. The seatbelt sign will not interrupt you.
- Pump in the lavatory if you must. Limit to once per flight (the air in the lavatory is dry, your skin will know).

In the hotel

- Wash parts in the bathroom sink with hot water and soap. Air-dry on a clean towel.
- Use the hotel mini-fridge for milk storage. Stick a thermometer in it if you can (some mini-fridges are warmer than they look).
- If your trip is more than 48 hours, ship the milk home. UPS overnight on dry ice. Some milk-shipping services exist. Look them up ahead of the trip.

When you land

- Move everything to a proper freezer within 4 hours of landing.

Daycare / caregiver handoff

A page to send with the milk.

Hi,

A few quick things about _____ and the milk:

DATE OF BIRTH: _____

WEIGHT: _____

USUAL FEED VOLUME: _____ oz per feed

USUAL FEED INTERVAL: every _____ hours

THE MILK

Bottles are dated. Use the oldest first.

Frozen milk can be thawed in the fridge overnight,
or by running the bottle under warm tap water.

Once thawed, use within 24 hours. Do not refreeze.

Heat in warm water, not the microwave.

Test on the inside of the wrist before feeding.

Any unused milk from a started bottle can be used
within 2 hours of the start of feeding. After
that, discard.

PACED BOTTLE FEEDING (so the baby still latches
when home with me):

- ☐ Hold the bottle horizontal, not tilted up.
- ☐ Let the baby pause when they pause.
- ☐ Switch sides halfway through.
- ☐ Use a slow-flow nipple.

THANK YOU.

_____ (parent name + signature)

Weekly check-in

A two-page reflection. Use weekly, or whenever something has shifted.

This week, the body

Supply this week (compared to last week):

☐ Higher ☐ Same ☐ Lower

What changed:

- ☐ Sleep was different
- ☐ Schedule was different
- ☐ A pump session was skipped
- ☐ Period returned
- ☐ Nothing obvious

Pumping pain (circle): none mild moderate severe

Latch at home (circle): normal shorter refusing

This week, the schedule

Sessions I made this week, out of intended: ____ / ____

Sessions I cut short for a meeting: ____

Sessions I missed: ____

This week, me

The hardest part of the week:

The unexpected good thing:

One thing I want to ask for next week:

The “I’m done” decision page

A single page, for whenever the decision happens. The decision is yours. It can be at month four, month nine, month thirteen, month twenty-two. It can be because you wanted to. It can be because of work. It can be because the baby is leading.

I am thinking about stopping pumping at work.

The reason (in one sentence, for me):

How I think the baby is feeling about it:

How my partner / family is feeling about it:

How I am feeling about it:

What I would like the wind-down to look like:

- ☐ Drop one session a week (gentlest)
- ☐ Drop one session every two weeks
- ☐ Stop cold (sometimes the right answer)

When I want it to be done by: _____

What I will do with the freezer stash:

You do not have to share this page with anyone. It is just for you to think it through.

A page for the version of you who didn't do this exactly right

A page at the end.

You went back to work and tried to keep feeding your baby with your body, in a world that does not actually make this easy. You did some of it. You did some of it imperfectly. You did some of it in a bathroom you wish you hadn't been in.

The baby was fed. The baby is fed. The how is much less important than the fact.

Save your milk-output log if you want, or don't. Save your conversation scripts in case you need them next time, or don't. Close this planner whenever you're done with it.

You did a hard, mostly-invisible thing. The world will not throw you a party. The baby, eventually, will figure it out and thank you in their own way, which will be by being a person.

That is the thing.

Numbers to keep

LACTATION CONSULTANT (IBCLC)

Name: _____ Number: _____

PEDIATRICIAN

Name: _____ Number: _____

HR / BENEFITS CONTACT

Name: _____ Number: _____

US NATIONAL BREASTFEEDING HELPLINE

1-800-994-9662 (Mon-Fri, English + Spanish)

US WAGE AND HOUR DIVISION (PUMP Act enforcement)

1-866-487-9243 (Mon-Fri)

US MATERNAL MENTAL HEALTH HOTLINE

1-833-852-6262 (24/7, free, confidential)



From [Soothemade Notes](#), a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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